

We

We

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Contents

Introduction	VII
We	I
<i>Afterword</i>	228
<i>Note on the Text</i>	230
<i>Notes</i>	230

We

1st Record

Conspectus:

THE ANNOUNCEMENT. THE WISEST OF LINES.
AN EPIC POEM.

I 'M SIMPLY COPYING – word for word – what's printed today in *The State Gazette*:

In 120 days the construction of the INTEGRAL is coming to an end. The great, historic hour when the first INTEGRAL will soar up into outer space is nigh. A thousand years ago, your heroic ancestors subjugated the entire globe to the power of the One State. A feat still more glorious falls to you: to integrate by means of the glass, electric, fire-breathing INTEGRAL the endless equation of the universe. It falls to you to subordinate to the beneficent yoke of reason the unknown beings living on other planets, possibly still in the savage state of freedom. If they do not understand that we bring them mathematically infallible happiness, it is our duty to force them to be happy. But before arms, we try the word.

In the name of the Benefactor, it is announced to all numbers of the One State:

Anyone who feels he has the power is duty-bound to compose treatises, epic poems, manifestos, odes or other works on the beauty and greatness of the One State.

This will be the first cargo the INTEGRAL will carry.

Long live the One State, long live the numbers, long live the Benefactor!

I write this and I feel: my cheeks are burning. Yes: to integrate the grandiose universal equation. Yes: to unbend the savage curve, to straighten it along a tangent – an asymptote – a straight line. Because the line of the One State is a straight line. The great, divine, precise, wise straight line – the wisest of lines...

I, Δ -503, the constructor of the *Integral* – I'm only one of the mathematicians of the One State. My pen, accustomed to figures, doesn't have the power to create the music of assonances and rhymes. I shall merely attempt to record what I see, what I think – more precisely, what *we* think (exactly that: we, and let that "WE" be the title of my records). But actually it will be the derivative of our life, the mathematically perfect life of the One State, and that being the case, will it not then be in itself, regardless of my will, an epic poem? It will – I believe and know it.

I write this and I feel: my cheeks are burning. This is probably similar to what a woman experiences when she senses inside herself for the first time the pulse of a new, still tiny, blind little person. It's me, and at the same time not me. And for long months it will be necessary to nourish it with one's juice, with one's blood, and then – to tear it painfully from oneself and lay it at the feet of the One State.

But I am ready, just like every one – or nearly every one – of us. I am ready.

2nd Record

Conspectus:

THE BALLET. QUADRATIC HARMONY. X.

IT'S SPRING. From beyond the Green Wall, from the savage, invisible plains, the wind carries the yellow, honeyed dust of some kind of flowers. This sweet dust makes your lips go dry – you're continually passing your tongue over them – and all the women you encounter must have sweet lips (and the men too, of course). This is something of a hindrance to logical thinking.

But then the sky! Blue, not spoilt by a single cloud (how savage were the tastes of the ancients if their poets could be inspired by those absurd, sloppy, stupidly jostling heaps of vapour). I like – I'm sure I won't be mistaken if I say: *we* like only such a sterile, irreproachable sky as this. On days like this the whole world is cast of that same unshakable, eternal glass as the Green Wall, as all of our constructions. On days like this you can see the very bluest depth of things, their various hitherto unknown, astounding equations – you can see them in something of the most customary, everyday kind.

Well, this, for example. In the morning today I was at the dock where the *Integral* is being constructed – and suddenly I saw the machine tools: with eyes closed, selflessly, the spheres of the regulators were spinning; the cranks, gleaming, were bending to the right and to the left; the balance beam rocked its shoulders proudly; in time with inaudible music the chisel of the grooving machine was curtsying. I suddenly saw all

the beauty of this grandiose ballet of machinery, flooded with gentle pale-blue sunshine.

And then – talking to myself: why is it beautiful? Why is the dance beautiful? The answer: because it is *unfree* movement, because the entire profound meaning of the dance lies precisely in absolute, aesthetic subordination, ideal unfreedom. And if it's true that our ancestors gave themselves up to dance at the most inspired moments of their lives (religious mysteries, military parades), then that means only one thing: the instinct of unfreedom has been organically inherent in man from ancient times, and we, in our present life, are only consciously...

I shall have to finish later: the annunciator has given a click. I raise my eyes: O-90, of course. And in half a minute she herself will be here: to fetch me for a walk.

Dear O-! – it's always seemed to me that she's like her name: ten centimetres or so shorter than the Maternal Norm – and as a result all roundly smoothed off, and the pink O – her mouth – is open to catch my every word. And also: the round, chubby little crease on her wrist – children sometimes have them.

When she came in, the logical flywheel was still really humming away inside me, and through force of inertia I started talking about the formula I had just established, which included all of us, and the machinery, and the dance.

"It's wonderful. Isn't it?" I asked.

"Yes, wonderful. It's spring," O-90 smiled at me pinkly.

Well, there, if you please: spring... She's on about spring. Women... I fell silent.

Downstairs. The avenue is full: in weather like this we usually spend the personal hour after lunch on a supplementary walk. As always, the Music Factory was singing the march of the One State with all its pipes. In rhythmic rows of four, enthusiastically beating time, walked the numbers – hundreds, thousands of

numbers, in pale-bluish unifs* with gold number plates on their chests – the state numbers of each man and woman. And I – we, a group of four, are one of the countless waves in this mighty stream. To my left, O-90 (if it had been one of my hairy ancestors writing this a thousand years or so ago, he would probably have referred to her with that ridiculous word “my”), to the right, two unfamiliar numbers or other, one female and one male.

The blissfully blue sky, the tiny baby suns in each of the number plates, the faces, undarkened by the madness of thoughts... Rays – you understand: all of some single, radiant, smiling matter. And the bronze rhythms: “Tra-ta-ta-tam, Tra-ta-ta-tam”, those bronze steps sparkling in the sunshine, and with every step, you rise ever higher, into the vertiginous blue...

And then, just as it had been in the morning at the dock, again I saw, as if only just now for the first time in my life – I saw everything: the immutable straight streets, the glass of the roadways spurting out rays, the divine parallelepipeds of the transparent dwellings, the quadratic harmony of the greyly pale-blue ranks. And so: it’s as if not whole generations, but I – specifically I – had defeated the old God and the old life, specifically I had created all this, and I’m like a tower, I’m afraid of moving my elbow, lest fragments of walls, domes, machinery should start raining down.

And then in an instant – a leap across the centuries, from + to –. I recalled (evidently association by contrast), I suddenly recalled a picture in a museum: their avenue from back then, from the twentieth centuries, a stunningly motley, muddled scrum of people, wheels, animals, placards, trees, colours, birds... And you know, they say it really was so – it could have been so. It seemed to me so implausible, so absurd, that I couldn’t contain myself and suddenly started roaring with laughter.

And at once an echo – laughter, from the right. I turned: into my eyes came white, extraordinarily white and sharp teeth, an unfamiliar female face.

“Forgive me,” she said, “but you were surveying everything with such inspiration – like some mythical god on the seventh day of creation. It seems to me you’re certain that you and no other created me too. I’m very flattered...”

All this without a smile, I would even have said – with a certain deference (perhaps she knows that I’m the constructor of the *Integral*). But I don’t know – in the eyes or the brows there’s some strange, irritating sort of X, and I can’t catch hold of it at all or give it numerical expression.

For some reason I became confused and, getting slightly muddled, started logically motivating my laughter. It was perfectly clear that this contrast, this impassable abyss between what is today and what was back then...

“But why ever impassable?” (What white teeth!) “A little bridge can be thrown over an abyss. Just you imagine: a drum, battalions, ranks – there was that too, you know – and therefore...”

“Well, yes: it’s clear!” I cried (this was an astonishing intersection of thoughts: she’d said – in almost my very own words – what I’d been recording before the walk). “You understand: even thoughts. It’s because nobody is ‘one alone’, but ‘one of’. We’re so identical...”

She:

“Are you certain?”

I saw the eyebrows, jerked up at a sharp angle towards the temples – like the sharp little horns of an X – and for some reason was knocked off my stride again; I glanced to the right, to the left – and...

To my right – her: slim, sharp, persistently supple, like a whip, I-330 (I can see her number now); to the left – O-: completely

different, composed wholly of circles, with the child's little crease on her arm; and on the edge of our group of four – a male number unknown to me, a twice-curved sort, like the letter "S". We were all different...

The one to the right, I-330, evidently intercepted my perplexed gaze – and, with a sigh:

"Yes... Alas!"

In essence, that "alas" was perfectly appropriate. But again there was something in her face or in her voice... With what was for me unusual sharpness I said:

"There's no alas. Science is growing, and it's clear – if not now, then in fifty, a hundred years..."

"Even everyone's noses..."

"Yes, their noses," I was now almost shouting. "Since there is – all the same, what basis is it for envy... Since I have a nose like a button, while somebody else..."

"Well, your nose may perhaps even be 'classical', as they used to say in the olden days. But your hands, now... No, come on, show me, show me your hands!"

I can't bear it when people look at my hands: all covered in hair, shaggy – some sort of absurd atavism. I reached out a hand and – in a voice as extraneous as possible – said:

"Simian."

She glanced at my hands, then at my face:

"But that's a most curious chord," she was weighing me up with her eyes as if on a set of scales, again there was a glimpse of little horns in the angles of her eyebrows.

"He's signed up to me," O-90 opened her mouth joyously and pinkly.

She'd have done better to keep quiet – this was completely irrelevant. In general, that dear O-... how can I put it... the speed of her tongue is incorrectly calculated, the second speed

of the tongue should always be a little less than the second speed of thought, and on absolutely no account vice versa.

At the end of the avenue, on the accumulator tower, the bell was resonantly striking 17. The personal hour was over. I-330 was walking away with that S-shaped male number. He has the sort of face that inspires deference and, I see it now, even seems to be familiar. I've met him somewhere – I can't remember where at the moment.

In farewell, I-330 – still just as X-ly – grinned at me.

"Come over to auditorium 112 the day after tomorrow."

I shrugged my shoulders:

"If I get an order – to the specific auditorium you mentioned..."

She, with a kind of incomprehensible certainty:

"You will."

This woman had just as unpleasant an effect on me as an unfactorizable irrational term that's crept by chance into an equation. And I was glad to remain alone with dear O-, albeit not for long.

Hand in hand we covered four lines of avenues. On the corner she had to go to the right, and I to the left.

"I'd so like to visit you today and lower the blinds. Specifically today, now..." O- shyly raised her round, crystalline-blue eyes to me.

She's funny. Well, what could I say to her? She visited me only yesterday and knows as well as I do that our nearest sexual day is the day after tomorrow. It's simply still her same problem of being "in advance of thought" – just as you can have the (sometimes harmful) advance feed of a spark in a motor.

In parting I twice... no, I'll be precise: thrice kissed her wonderful blue eyes, not spoilt by one little cloud.

3rd Record

Conspectus:

A JACKET. THE WALL. THE TABLET.

I 'VE LOOKED THROUGH ALL that was written yesterday – and I can see: I was writing insufficiently clearly. That is, it's all perfectly clear for any one of *us*. But who's to know: maybe you, the unknown ones to whom the *Integral* will bring my notes, maybe you've read the great book of civilization only as far as the page our ancestors had some 900 years ago. Maybe you don't know even such basics as the Tablet of Hours, Personal Hours, the Maternal Norm, the Green Wall, the Benefactor. I find it ridiculous – and at the same time very hard to talk about it all. It's just the same as if a writer of, let's say, the twentieth century or so had to explain in his novel what “a jacket”, “an apartment”, “a wife” was. But then, if his novel is translated for savages – is it really conceivable to do without notes regarding “a jacket”?

I'm sure the savage gazed at “a jacket” and thought: “Well, what's the point of that? It's just a burden.” It seems to me that you too will gaze in exactly the same way when I tell you that, since the time of the Two Hundred Years War, none of us has been beyond the Green Wall.

But, my dears, you do need to think a little, it's very helpful. I mean, it's clear: the whole of human history, as far as we know it, is the history of the transition from nomadic forms to ever more settled ones. Does it not follow from this that the most

settled form of life (ours) is at the same time also the most perfect (ours)? If people used to rush around the earth from one end to the other, well, that was only in prehistoric times, when there were nations, wars, trade, the discoveries of all sorts of Americas. But why – for whom is it necessary now?

I admit: the habit of this settled way of life was achieved not without difficulty and not immediately. When all the roads were destroyed and became overgrown with grass during the Two Hundred Years War, to begin with, it must have seemed very inconvenient to live in cities cut off from one another by green jungles. But what of it? After man's tail fell off, he probably didn't learn at once how to drive flies away without the help of a tail either. To begin with, he was doubtless miserable without a tail. But now – can you imagine yourself having a tail? Or: can you imagine yourself in the street naked, without “a jacket” (it's possible that you still stroll around in “jackets”)? And it's the same here: I can't picture the city not clothed with the Green Wall, I can't picture life not draped in the numerical raiment of the Tablet.

The Tablet... Right now, from a wall in my room, its purple numerals on a golden field look me sternly and tenderly in the eye. You involuntarily remember what was known among the ancients as “an icon”, and I feel like composing poetry or prayers (which are one and the same). Ah, why am I not a poet, to sing of you worthily, O Tablet, O heart and pulse of the One State?

All of us (and maybe you too), while still children, in school, used to read the greatest of the monuments of ancient literature that have come down to us – *The Railway Timetable*. But set even that alongside the Tablet – and you'll see alongside one another graphite and diamond: one and the same thing is in both of them – C, carbon – but how eternal, transparent,

how radiant is the diamond. Whose breath isn't taken away when you're racing with a clatter through the pages of *The Timetable*? But the Tablet of Hours turns each of us in reality into the steel, six-wheeled hero of the great epic poem. Each morning, with six-wheeled precision, at one and the same hour and at one and the same minute – we, the millions, rise as one. At one and the same hour, uni-millionly, we start work – uni-millionly we end. And merging into a single, million-armed body, at one and the same second, designated by the Tablet, we lift our spoons to our mouths – and at one and the same second we go out for a walk, and we go to an auditorium, to the Hall of Taylor Exercises,* we go off to bed...

I shall be completely candid: even we don't yet have an absolutely precise solution to the problem of happiness: twice a day – from 16 to 17 and from 21 to 22 – the single powerful organism breaks up into individual cells: these are the Personal Hours established by the Tablet. At these hours you will see: in the rooms of some, chastely lowered blinds, others walk rhythmically along the avenue, down the brass steps of 'The March', still others – like me now – are at a desk. But I firmly believe – let them call me an idealist and a fantasist – I believe: sooner or later – but sometime – we will find a place in the common formula for these hours too, sometime all 86,400 seconds will be included in the Tablet of Hours.

I've had to read and hear many improbable things about the times when people still lived in a free, i.e. unorganized, savage condition. But the most improbable always seemed to me precisely this: how the state authority back then, even if embryonic, could have allowed people to live without anything at all like our Tablet, without compulsory walks, without precise regulation of the times of food, they got up and went to bed whenever it entered their heads; some historians even say

that in those days, apparently, lights would burn in the streets all night, and all night people would walk and ride through the streets.

Now I can't make sense of that at all. I mean, however limited their reason, they ought nonetheless to have understood that such a life was the most genuine universal murder – slow murder though, from day to day. The state (humaneness) forbade the killing of one person, but did not forbid the half-killing of millions. Killing one person, i.e. reducing the sum of human lives by fifty years, that's criminal, while reducing the sum of human lives by fifty million years, that's not criminal. Well, isn't that ridiculous? Here, this mathematical-moral problem will be solved in half a minute by any ten-year-old number; there, they couldn't do it – not all their Kants put together* (because not one of the Kants had the sense to construct a system of scientific ethics, i.e. one based on subtraction, addition, division and multiplication).

And there's this – isn't it absurd that a state (it dared to call itself a state!) could leave sexual life without any sort of control? Whoever wanted, whenever and however much... Completely unscientifically, like wild animals. And like wild animals, blindly, they gave birth to children. Isn't it ridiculous: to know plant-breeding, poultry-breeding, fish-breeding (we have precise data that they knew all this) and not to be able to reach the final rung of that logical ladder: child-breeding. Not to hit upon the idea of our Maternal and Paternal Norms.

It's so ridiculous, so implausible, that now I've written it down I'm afraid: what if you, unknown readers, take me for a cruel joker? What if you think I simply want to mock you, and am recounting, with a serious air, the most complete rubbish?

But the first thing is: I'm not capable of jokes – included as an implicit function in any joke is a falsehood; and the

second thing is: the One State's Science asserts that the life of the ancients was precisely like that, and the One State's Science cannot be mistaken. And anyway, where could state logic have come from back then, when people lived in the state of freedom, i.e. of wild animals, apes, the herd? What can be demanded of them, if even in our times – from somewhere at the bottom, from the shaggy depths – a savage, simian echo can still occasionally be heard?

Happily, only occasionally. Happily, these are only minor breakdowns of component parts: it's easy to repair them without stopping the eternal, great running of the whole Machine. And to throw out a bent bolt, we have the skilled, heavy hand of the Benefactor, we have the experienced eye of the Guardians...

Yes, incidentally, I've remembered now: that one yesterday, twice curved like an S – I think I've had occasion to see him coming out of the Bureau of Guardians. Now I understand why I experienced that instinctive feeling of deference towards him and a sort of awkwardness when, right in front of him, that strange I... I must confess, that I-...

The bell's ringing for bed: 22 ½. Until tomorrow.

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